

in meetings would ultimately lead to increased productivity, which is the ultimate objective of convening a meeting. While none of the counter-MRS ideas have been tested empirically yet, Allen says one trick with promise is for employees to identify things that quickly change their mood from negative to positive. As simple as it sounds, finding a personal happy place, going there and then coming straight back to work might be key to facilitating recovery.

- M) Leaders should see also themselves as “stewards of everyone else’s valuable time”, adds Steven Rogelberg, author of *The Surprising Science of Meetings*. Having the skills to foresee potential traps and treat employees’ endurance with care allows leaders to provide effective short-term deterrents to MRS.
- N) Most important, however, is for organisations to awaken to the concept of meetings being flexible, says Allen. By reshaping the way they prioritise employees’ time, companies can eliminate the very sources of MRS in their tracks.
36. Although employees are said to be fatigued by meetings, the condition has not been considered worthy of further research until recently.
37. Mroz and his team compiled a list of what to do and what not to do to remedy the problem of MRS.
38. Companies can get rid of the root cause of MRS if they give priority to workers’ time.
39. If workers are exhausted to a dangerous degree, it is extremely hard for them to transition to the next task.
40. Employees in America spend a lot of time attending meetings while the number of hours managers meet is several times more.
41. Phyllis Hartman has learned by herself many of the ways Mroz suggested in his study and made remarkable success in freeing herself from unnecessary meetings.

42. When meetings continue too long or don't engage employees, they deplete vitality.
43. When the time of meetings is reduced, employees will be more engaged in the meetings they do participate in.
44. Some employees consider meetings one of the most dispensable parts of the workday.
45. According to Mroz, if all his suggestions were applied, a very obvious change would be a steep decrease in the number of meetings scheduled.

Section C

Directions: *There are 2 passages in this section. Each passage is followed by some questions or unfinished statements. For each of them there are four choices marked A), B), C) and D). You should decide on the best choice and mark the corresponding letter on **Answer Sheet 2** with a single line through the centre.*

Passage One

Questions 46 to 50 are based on the following passage.

Sarcasm and jazz have something surprisingly in common: You know them when you hear them. Sarcasm is mostly understood through tone of voice, which is used to portray the opposite of the literal words. For example, when someone says, "Well, that's exactly what I need right now," their tone can tell you it's not what they need at all.

Most frequently, sarcasm highlights an irritation or is, quite simply, mean.

If you want to be happier and improve your relationships, cut out sarcasm. Why? Because sarcasm is actually hostility disguised as humor.

Despite smiling outwardly, many people who receive sarcastic comments feel put down and often think the sarcastic person is rude, or contemptible. Indeed, it's not surprising that the origin of the word sarcasm derives from the Greek word "sarkazein" which literally means "to tear or strip the flesh off." Hence, it's no wonder that sarcasm is often preceded by the word "cutting" and that it hurts.

What's more, since actions strongly determine thoughts and feelings, when a person consistently acts sarcastically it may only serve to heighten their underlying hostility and insecurity. After all, when you come right down to it, sarcasm can be used as a subtle form of bullying—and most bullies are angry, insecure, or cowardly.

Alternatively, when a person stops voicing negative comments, especially sarcastic ones, they may soon start to feel happier and more self-confident. Also, other people in their life benefit even more because they no longer have to hear the emotionally hurtful language of sarcasm.

Now, I'm not saying all sarcasm is bad. It may just be better used sparingly—like a potent spice in cooking. Too much of the spice, and the dish will be overwhelmed by it. Similarly, an occasional dash of sarcastic wit can spice up a chat and add an element of humor to it. But a big or steady serving of sarcasm will overwhelm the emotional flavor of any conversation and can taste very bitter to its recipient.

So, tone down the sarcasm and work on clever wit instead, which is usually without any hostility and thus more appreciated by those you're communicating with. In essence, sarcasm is easy while true, harmless wit takes talent.

Thus, the main difference between wit and sarcasm is that, as already stated, sarcasm is often hostility disguised as humor. It can be intended to hurt and is often bitter and biting. Witty statements are usually in response to someone's unhelpful remarks or behaviors, and the intent is to untangle and clarify the issue by emphasizing its absurdities. Sarcastic statements are expressed in a cutting manner; witty remarks are delivered with undisguised and harmless humor.

46. Why does the author say sarcasm and jazz have something surprisingly in common?

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| A) Both are recognized when heard. | C) Both mean the opposite of what they appear to. |
| B) Both have exactly the same tone. | D) Both have hidden in them an evident irritation. |

47. How do many people feel when they hear sarcastic comments?
- A) They feel hostile towards the sarcastic person.
 - B) They feel belittled and disrespected.
 - C) They feel a strong urge to retaliate.
 - D) They feel incapable of disguising their irritation.
48. What happens when a person consistently acts sarcastically?
- A) They feel their dignity greatly heightened.
 - B) They feel increasingly insecure and hostile.
 - C) They endure hostility under the disguise of humor.
 - D) They taste bitterness even in pleasant interactions.
49. What does the author say about people quitting sarcastic comments?
- A) It makes others happier and more self-confident.
 - B) It restrains them from being irritating and bullying.
 - C) It benefits not only themselves but also those around them.
 - D) It shields them from negative comments and outright hostility.
50. What is the chief difference between a speaker's wit and sarcasm?
- A) Their clarity.
 - B) Their appreciation.
 - C) Their emphasis.
 - D) Their intention.

Passage Two

Questions 51 to 55 are based on the following passage.

Variability is crucially important for learning new skills. Consider learning how to serve in tennis. Should you always practise serving from the exactly same location on the court, aiming at the same spot? Although practising in more variable conditions will be slower at first, it will likely make you a better tennis player in the end. This is because variability leads to better generalisation of what is learned.

This principle is found in many domains, including speech perception and learning categories. For instance, infants will struggle to learn the category “dog” if they are only exposed to Chihuahuas, instead of many different kinds of dogs.

“There are over ten different names for this basic principle,” says Limor Raviv, the senior investigator of a recent study. “Learning from less variable input is often fast, but may fail to generalise to new stimuli.”

To identify key patterns and understand the underlying principles of variability effects, Raviv and her colleagues reviewed over 150 studies on variability and generalisation across fields, including computer science, linguistics, categorisation, visual perception and formal education.

The researchers discovered that, across studies, the term variability can refer to at least four different